

culture are a totem; to them can be ascribed no inherent aberrant tendency or fault.

There is ample reason to be interested in the history of speculative excess and its effects for its own sake. One relishes, especially if from afar, the drama of mass insanity. There is a rewarding sense of personal foresight in knowing of the invariable end of each episode. But there is also a high practical utility in observing how reliably the common features just cited recur. Seeing the earlier of the symptoms reemerge, as they will, there is a chance—a slim chance, to be sure, given the sweeping power of financial euphoria—that otherwise vulnerable individuals will be warned. To this end, I now turn to the great speculative episodes of the past and their common features.